

Afternoon Tea Around the World

The gentle tinkling of china teacups announces the civilized interlude between 3 and 5 PM when the world stops for tea in both cozy English tearooms and fancy East Asian hotels. This is the time to sit back and savor a long-standing and treasured ritual.

YORKSHIRE

Bettys moderate

6–8 St. Helen's Square, York; www.bettys.co.uk

Established in 1919, Bettys has six tearooms scattered around Yorkshire. The York establishment must be the most glamorous tearoom in England, an Art Deco gem whose elegant interior was inspired by the famous ocean liner *Queen Mary*. From the craft bakery emerge extraordinary breads, cakes, and confections, including the specialty cherry-and-almond "Fat Rascals," while Bettys' house-blend Yorkshire Tea is an English classic.

The Black Swan Tearoom moderate

Market Place, Helmsley; www.blackswan-helmsley.co.uk

Yorkshire's market towns are full of traditional, honest-to-goodness cafés, but there's far more style in evidence in this boutique tearoom and patisserie (a Tea Guild award-winner) attached to a classy country hotel. A rare and exotic tea menu ranges far and wide, or order afternoon tea with Champagne for a real indulgence.

Swinton Park moderate

Masham, Ripon; www.swintonpark.com

For a taste of the noble life, take tea in Swinton Park castle hotel, which is set in 200 acres of private parkland on the eastern fringes of the Yorkshire Dales. The local choice here is a "Wensleydale Tea," served with the crumbly, eponymous cheese from the Dales and Yorkshire fruitcake.

ALSO IN ENGLAND

London offers a stylish introduction to afternoon tea in a score or more famous hotels and glitzy stores, while in every region of England there's a seductive café or tearoom devoted to serving the perfect cream tea.

Otterton Mill inexpensive

Otterton, Budleigh Salterton, Devon; www.ottertonmill.com

Of the many contenders for the best Devonshire cream tea, they go the extra mile at Otterton Mill, which is set in a glorious riverside location in the wildlife-rich Otter Valley. The scones are made daily using their own milled flour, both clotted cream and jellies are supplied by nearby artisan producers, and the tea is organic and fair trade.

Cavendish Rooms moderate

Chatsworth House, Bakewell, Derbyshire; www.chatsworth.org

Enjoy a gracious afternoon tea that's entirely in keeping with the surroundings at Chatsworth House, Britain's finest Baroque stately home, the ancestral digs of the Dukes of Devonshire. Dainty cakes and pastries made by Chatsworth's own bakers are served in what is surely the most elegant stable block in the land, a glorious 18th-century space given a contemporary makeover.

De Grey's Tea Rooms moderate

Broad Street, Ludlow, Shropshire; www.degreys.co.uk

In central England's foodie capital, Ludlow, afternoon tea is at its traditional best at De Grey's, a half-timbered Tudor town house with an atmospheric oak-beamed interior and black-and-white-clad staff. An in-house bakery produces wonderful cakes and pastries, and if you eat more than is wise, you may be grateful to learn that there are also very cozy guest accommodations.

The Secret Garden moderate

Mersham-le-Hatch, Hythe Road, Ashford, Kent; www.secretgardenkent.co.uk

In the county of Kent — the so-called "garden of England" — afternoon tea and handsome locations go hand in hand, as in this restored coach house and impressive Victorian walled garden. The strawberry cream tea served here incorporates locally sourced jellies and clotted cream, while seasonal variations add a glass of Kentish sparkling wine or even mince pies and mulled wine at Christmas.

The Tea Cosy moderate

3 George Street, Kemptown, Brighton, East Sussex; www.theteacosy.co.uk

In the south coast's most flamboyant resort, this charming tearoom is dedicated, with its tongue

Below (top to bottom) Cakes await service at Bettys, purveyor of exquisite afternoon teas since 1919; the Piccadilly frontage of Fortnum & Mason in London, grocer to the English gentry

Right (top to bottom) A staunchly colonial tea in Hong Kong, with scones, clotted cream, and strawberry jam; afternoon tea at Raffles, Singapore; taking tea English-style in Jaipur, India

